

KEEPER OF TAAL Pandit Chatur Lal performing

ECHOES OF A MAESTRO

A centenary tribute honours tabla maestro **Pandit Chatur Lal**, who, alongside Pandit Ravi Shankar, introduced Indian rhythm to the world stage

On April 16, 2026, Safdarjung's Tomb in Delhi will host a special evening marking the birth centenary of Pandit Chatur Lal—one of the first musicians to take Indian classical percussion to global audiences. Curated by his family, the programme is designed to go beyond performance. It will open with a gallery of archival material, including photographs, documents and personal accounts sourced from across the many countries he performed in. "It's really about helping people understand who he was, beyond just the name," says Shruti Chatur Lal, his granddaughter and artistic director and curator of the Pandit Chatur Lal Festival. A short film will follow, featuring archival footage and reflections from leading figures such as Pandit Jasraj and Ustad Bismillah Khan, situating Chatur Lal within the larger history of Indian classical music.

The musical programming reflects a deliberate curatorial choice. Singer Anup Jalota will headline the evening with a set of bhajans. "We wanted Delhi to have a certain spiritual mood," Shruti explains. "In Udaipur, we had qawwali. When we have the programme in Mumbai, we're planning a percussion-focused evening. Each city has been approached differently." Percussionist Sivamani joins as a special guest in what was, by the organiser's account, a spontaneous addition. The lineup also includes a performance by Shruti's brother Pranshu Chatur Lal and his ensemble Brahmaand, offering a contemporary interpretation of the legacy.

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In the 1950s, alongside Pandit Ravi Shankar, Chatur Lal toured internationally, introducing audiences to the intricacies of Indian rhythm at a time when the form was largely unfamiliar outside the country. Their collaboration on the Canadian film, *A Chairy Tale*, earned an Academy Award nomination and a BAFTA honour. He was also part of landmark performances at UNESCO House in Paris, early cross-cultural collaborations, and one of the first East-West percussion dialogues with jazz drummer Papa Jo Jones. Through recordings and concerts, he helped position the tabla as a solo instrument in its own right.

The Delhi event is part of a year-long centenary series that began in Udaipur and will travel to cities across India and internationally, including Europe, the US and Australia—places where he had once performed. "We're trying to revisit the spaces that were part of his journey," says Shruti. "That, for us, is the most meaningful way to honour him." ■

—Geetika Sachdev